



Holidays are better with T-Mobile



Worries on drug boat strikes got sidestepped

Officials say White House blew past legal concerns as it pursued campaign

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA, WARREN P. STROBEL AND ALEX HORTON

President Donald Trump and his top White House aides pushed for lethal strikes on Western Hemisphere drug traffickers almost as soon as they took office in January, and in the past 10 months have repeatedly steamrolled or sidestepped government lawyers who questioned whether the provocative policy was legal, according to multiple current and former officials familiar with the debates.

As Trump weighs what could be imminent military action against Venezuela and its leader, Nicolás Maduro, while striking at alleged drug boats in the Caribbean Sea and eastern Pacific Ocean, new details are emerging about the evolution of a strategy that involves unprecedented U.S. military force against the narcotics trade — and, critics say, outsize legal risk.

The deadly attacks on small boats are being carried out by the Pentagon, which at Trump's orders has amassed a vast array of warships, aircraft and troops in the region, including the largest U.S. aircraft carrier.

But early on, according to two people familiar with the matter, the administration proposed having the CIA use its unique covert authorities to conduct the

SEE CIA ON A6

Leaflets over Caracas: U.S. mulls tactic to pressure Maduro. **A20**



Ester Souza, 8, at the evangelical church led by her parents in Votuporanga, Brazil, where she delivers sermons.

Ester Souza looks into the mirror and begins her transformation. She changes out of her pink T-shirt and shorts with flowers and butterflies and into a sober brown blouse and dress slacks. She weaves her long curly hair into two braids on top of her head. A touch of makeup and her expression shifts. The easy smile gives way to a look of deep focus.

"My heart is racing," she says. She knows dozens of people are waiting for her.

When she steps up to the pulpit of her father's small church in rural São Paulo state, the congregation leans in. Ester returns her listeners' focus. Standing before an open Bible, preternaturally poised, she grips the

In Catholic Brazil, child preachers help spread evangelicalism

An 8-year-old blends faith and social media to win souls in Latin America's largest nation

BY MARINA DIAS
IN VOTUPORANGA, BRAZIL

microphone and starts to preach. Pain cannot corrupt hope, she promises, because suffering can be turned into a testimony. It's her own story. She describes the kidney infection she had in 2020, her two months in the hospital, the wait for a transplant, the near-daily hemodialysis, how close she came to death.

Some in the congregation sob. Some cheer. They believe she's a miracle.

Ester raises a hand toward the heavens, takes a deep breath and releases her core message.

"The doctors said no," she says, "but God said yes."

The congregation erupts in tearful cries of "Hallelujah!" and "Praise the Lord!"

SEE BRAZIL ON A16

Nations balk at fossil fuel cap

CLIMATE PACT A WIN FOR OIL, GAS, COAL

Adapting to warming is focus a decade after Paris

BY JAKE SPRING, MARINA DIAS AND CHICO HARLAN

BELÉM, BRAZIL — Nearly 200 countries agreed Saturday to step up efforts to adapt to global warming and warned about the risks of inaction, but rejected proposals to directly address the fossil fuels warming the planet.

The deal, reached at the annual United Nations climate talks in Brazil's Amazon rainforest, represents a win for the oil, gas and coal industries and underscores the extent to which the global political environment has shifted since the same group struck the Paris agreement a decade ago.

That accord pledged to keep the world "well below" a temperature rise of 2 degrees Celsius (3.6 degrees Fahrenheit) compared to pre-industry levels and strive to limit warming to 1.5

SEE CLIMATE ON A18

U.S. edict, aides' scandal put Zelensky on back foot

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY, SERHIY MORGUNOV, KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV AND DAVID L. STERN

KYIV — Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky is facing a stunning challenge to his presidency as major corruption allegations rock the wartime leader's innermost circle just as Washington ramps up pressure for him to agree to an unfavorable peace deal.

The corruption scandal has fueled rage that the country's ruling elite may have lined their own pockets as they sent troops to die in the name of democracy and Western values — compounding pressure on Zelensky, who risks losing the trust of his country even as he negotiates for its future on the world stage.

Zelensky is left with few options to regain that trust,

SEE UKRAINE ON A19

Trump doubles down: He again prods Zelensky on peace deal. **A19**



ILLUSTRATION BY JULIE BENBASSAT/ FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Best books of 2025
We break it down across genre and medium. **Book World**

Armed with wealth, billionaires stake their claim in elections

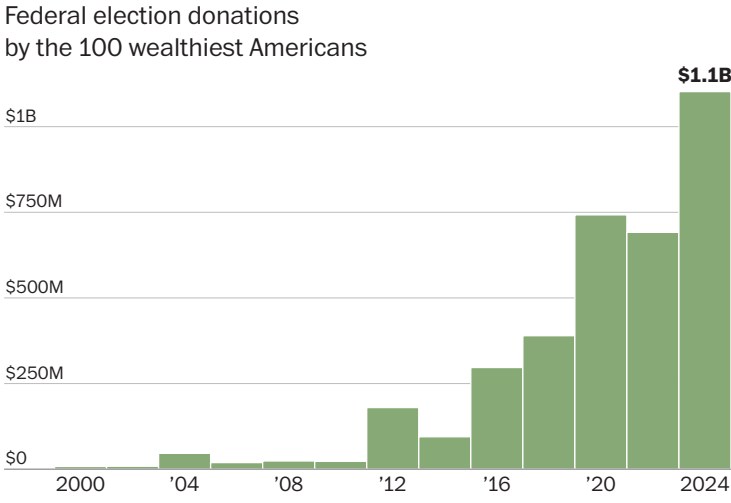
Legal, economic and political changes reshape the relationship between money and power in the U.S.

BY BETH REINHARD, NAFTALI BENDAVID, CLARA ENCE MORSE AND AARON SCHAFER

New York City billionaire John Catsimatidis has long been immersed in politics. But last year the Republican real estate and oil tycoon donated more money than he ever had before — \$2.4 million to support Donald Trump and congressional Republicans, nearly twice as much as he gave in 2016.

Catsimatidis said he feels a growing urgency to try to influence the course of American politics, given the wide divergence between the two parties.

"If you're a billionaire, you want to stay a billionaire," said Catsimatidis, whose net worth is



Note: Data reflects donations to Federal Election Commission committees and to 527 nonprofit organizations.

Poll: Most Americans dislike spending by ultrarich in elections. **A13**

estimated at \$4.5 billion. It's not just about his own wealth, he said, adding, "I worry about America and the way of life we have."

In an era defined by major political divisions and massive wealth accumulation for the richest Americans, billionaires are spending unprecedented amounts on U.S. politics. Dozens have stepped up their political giving in recent years, leading to a record-breaking surge of donations by the ultrarich in 2024. Since 2000, political giving by the wealthiest 100 Americans to federal elections has gone up almost 140 times, well outpacing the growing costs of campaigns, a Washington Post analysis found.

SEE BILLIONAIRES ON A12

BUSINESS
Why one of the most thriving U.S. industries is shedding jobs. **B11**

TRAVEL
One Dutch museum is an architectural marvel with an urgent mission.

**FOOD**
Feast your eyes on a bounty of recipes and tips for Thanksgiving.

COMICS.....	INSERT
METRO.....	B18
OBITUARIES.....	B22
OPINION PAGES.....	A21
POLITICS & THE NATION.....	A4
WORLD NEWS.....	A15

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54409



Holiday savings for 55+

Our best price for 2 lines – \$30 mo./line

With Autopay; plus taxes & fees. With 24 mo. bill credits when you switch on a qualifying plan. For well-qualified customers; plus tax & \$35 device connection charge.

